



▲ BARREL SPONGES

Giant barrel sponges are found on the tropical coral reefs of the Caribbean Sea. They can measure up to 6 ft (1.8 m) across their hollow, barrel-shaped bodies.

LIVE SPONGE

Some of the simplest reef animals are sponges. They live by pumping water through their spongy body walls to filter out tiny food particles. Their springy, water-holding skeletons are still used today as natural bath sponges.

FILTER FEEDERS

Most of the plantlike animals on the reefs live by filtering small animals and other food from moving water. This enables them to survive without needing to roam over the reefs actively looking for food. They include the tunicates, which pump the water through basketlike filters inside their hollow bodies. Some are solitary creatures, but most live in colonies attached to the coral rock.

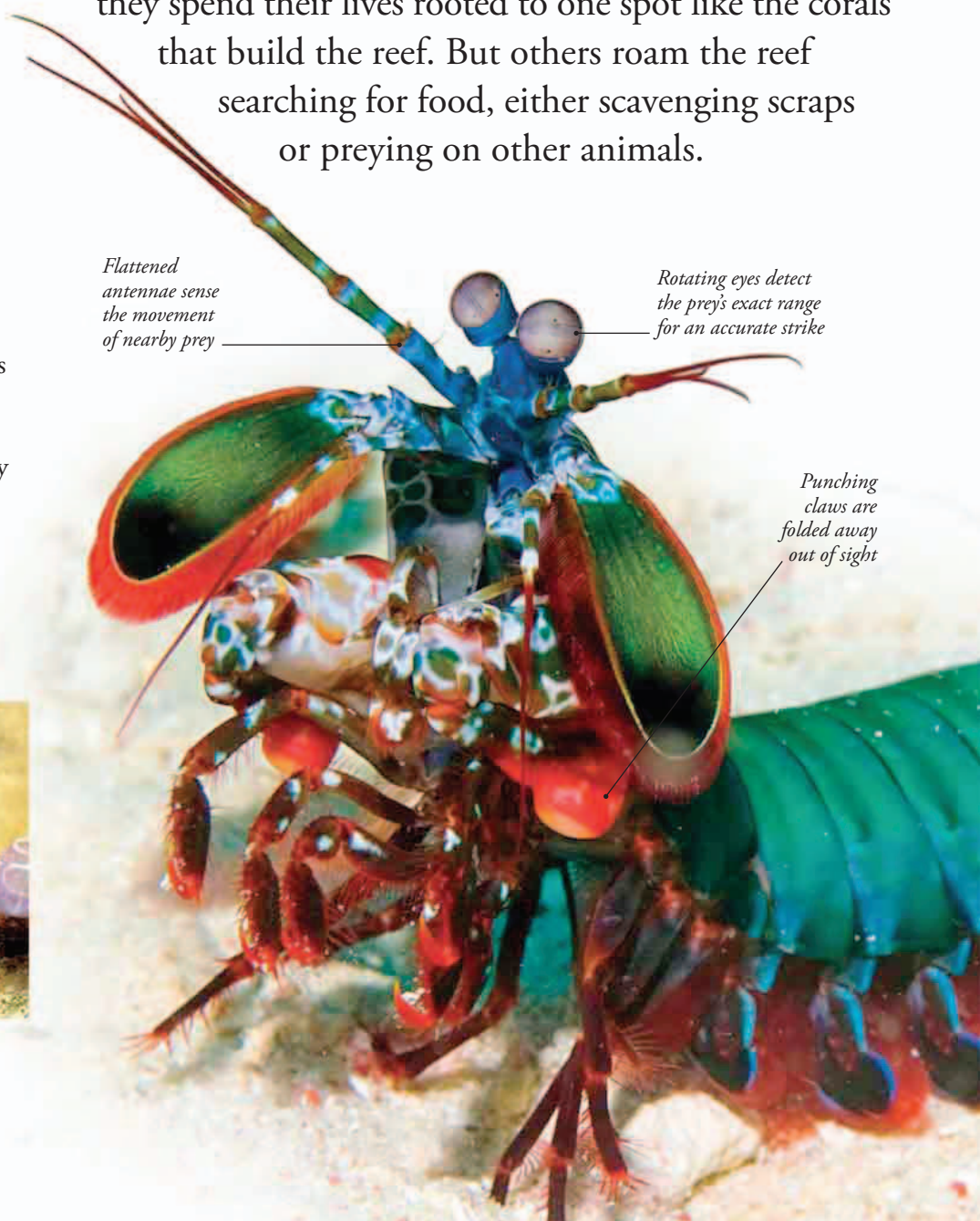


▲ BLUE BELL TUNICATES

Each tunicate in this colony draws water in through a "mouth" at the top of its body and pumps it out through an opening at the side.

Reef invertebrates

Colorful fish are the most obvious coral reef animals, but the reefs are alive with other creatures too. Most of these are various types of invertebrates (animals without backbones). They include crustaceans such as shrimp and crabs, and echinoderms such as starfish. Some of the animals look more like plants because they spend their lives rooted to one spot like the corals that build the reef. But others roam the reef searching for food, either scavenging scraps or preying on other animals.



Flattened antennae sense the movement of nearby prey

Rotating eyes detect the prey's exact range for an accurate strike

Punching claws are folded away out of sight